NEW HAVEN, UNITED STATES

Yale Center for British Art: Masterpieces

Twenty works from the Yale Center for British Art place exceptional sights beside portraits, working drawings and familiar ground.



The broad sail in J. M. W. Turner's Dordrecht painting has little wind to use. Small activities continue around it, making the harbour's calm something more specific than an empty scene. Elsewhere in this selection, a comet crosses the sky and Vesuvius erupts above tiny witnesses. Such events depend on ordinary surroundings to make their scale intelligible. The drawings offer another kind of comparison: large designs beside small studies, worked areas beside paper left almost bare. These shifts reward looking at what has received attention and what has been left out. Two different Turners appear here: J. M. W. Turner and William Turner of Oxford.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/yale-center-british-art

The selection · 20

1. Dort, or Dordrecht: The Dort Packet-Boat from Rotterdam Becalmed
   J. M. W. Turner · 1818
2. Hadleigh Castle
   John Constable · 1829
3. A Zebra
   George Stubbs · 1763
4. The Gravenor Family
   Thomas Gainsborough · c.1752 - 1754
5. William Cavendish, Marquess of Hartington
   William Hogarth · 1741
6. Mount Vesuvius in Eruption
   J. M. W. Turner · 1817
7. Donati's Comet
   William Turner of Oxford · 1858–1859
8. Elizabeth Siddal
   Dante Gabriel Rossetti · 1854–1855
9. Bartholomew Beale
   Mary Beale · 1663–1664
10. First Class: The Meeting
    Abraham Solomon · 1855
11. Study for The Shearers
    Samuel Palmer · 1833–1834
12. Christmas
    Samuel Palmer · 1850
13. Interior of the New Bedford
    Spencer Gore · 1908–1909
14. Study for a Deer-Hunting Mural
    Spencer Gore · 1912
15. Study for a Mural: Old Man in a Landscape
    Spencer Gore · 1912
16. The Entrance Front of Hayley's House at Eartham
    William Blake · 1801
17. The Exeter College Eight on the Isis
    William Turner of Oxford · 1824
18. Bridge at Corpo di Cava
    Hannah Emma Palmer · 1838
19. Tysoe Windmill and Church, Warwickshire
    William Turner of Oxford · 1849
20. Scene near Shipton on Cherwell
    William Turner of Oxford · 1835

01 / 20

Dort, or Dordrecht: The Dort Packet-Boat from Rotterdam Becalmed

J. M. W. Turner

1818 · Oil on canvas · Yale Center for British Art



Dort, the Dort Packet Boat from Rotterdam Bacalmed. WikiArt; J. M. W. Turner. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The large sail has a substantial presence above reflective water, though the boat has little wind to carry it forward. Small vessels and people keep the harbour occupied. Turner therefore distinguishes still weather from inactivity: the calm belongs to the whole setting without stopping every task within it. The low town and luminous sky give the clustered boats space, making their temporary suspension legible across the view.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Hadleigh Castle

John Constable

1829 · Oil on canvas · Yale Center for British Art



John Constable. Hadleigh Castle. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/john-constable/hadleigh-castle-1829 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Broken towers stand above the estuary, their rough outlines meeting an unsettled sky. Constable gives the ruins enough weight to organise the landscape without making them stable or complete. A path and small figures keep the near slope in use. Human activity continues beside damaged masonry; the scene contains both the persistence of everyday passage and structures that no longer perform their original purpose.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

A Zebra

George Stubbs

1763 · Yale Center for British Art



George Stubbs. A Zebra. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/george-stubbs/a-zebra-1763 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The zebra stands in profile, its illuminated stripes distinct against dark trees. Stubbs gives the animal the concentrated attention of an individual portrait. This was Queen Charlotte's zebra, brought to Britain as a gift in 1762 and publicly exhibited. The wooded setting should not be mistaken for its natural habitat. Its unusual presence belongs to the history of transporting and displaying animals, not simply to a painter's choice of pattern.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

The Gravenor Family

Thomas Gainsborough

c.1752 - 1754 · Oil on canvas · Yale Center for British Art



Thomas Gainsborough. Mr. and Mrs. John Gravenor and their Daughters, Elizabeth and Ann. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/thomas-gainsborough/mr-and-mrs-john-gravenor-and-their-daughters-elizabeth-and-ann-1754 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

A man, woman and two girls form a compact group beneath a tree. Gainsborough makes their relationship readable through placement and the meeting of their differently coloured clothes. There is no domestic incident that everyone must act out. The landscape gives the group a shared setting beyond individual likenesses, allowing family position and social presentation to emerge from how the figures occupy the same piece of ground.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

William Cavendish, Marquess of Hartington

William Hogarth

1741 · Yale Center for British Art



William Hogarth. William Cavendish, Marquess of Hartington, Later 4th Duke of Devonshire. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Embroidery spreads across the young man's coat, while his pale face and white neckcloth remain distinct against darkness. Hogarth lets costume announce rank without allowing it to replace the sitter. The turn of the body gives the elaborate garment changing planes rather than a flat frontal display. Looking moves between the fine details that establish status and the face that keeps that status attached to a particular person.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Mount Vesuvius in Eruption

J. M. W. Turner

1817 · Watercolour on paper · Yale Center for British Art



Mount Vesuvius in Eruption. WikiArt; J. M. W. Turner. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Fire and illuminated smoke rise above dark slopes, while water carries their reflection into the lower view. Small vessels and foreground figures provide a human measure for an event that exceeds them. Turner's light joins the eruption to its surroundings, making it difficult to look at the mountain as a separate object. The witnesses matter precisely because they occupy so little of the space governed by it.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Donati's Comet

William Turner of Oxford

1858–1859 · Yale Center for British Art



William Turner. Donati's Comet. Image credit: William Turner; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

William Turner of Oxford leaves trees and low ground near the bottom of the picture, giving most of the field to the blue sky and its pale comet. The ordinary horizon helps distinguish the celestial event from an abstract streak of light. Its scale and direction become readable against a place that remains still beneath it. This is a different artist from J. M. W. Turner, represented elsewhere in the selection.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1975.4.1767

08 / 20

Elizabeth Siddal

Dante Gabriel Rossetti

1854–1855 · Yale Center for British Art



Dante Gabriel Rossetti. Miss Elizabeth Siddal. Image credit: Dante Gabriel Rossetti; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

Siddal rests against a chair with her hands gathered over a full skirt. Rossetti concentrates darker hatching around the head and upper body, leaving other passages less developed. The difference in finish directs attention without pretending that every part has been resolved equally. The sheet retains the uneven priorities of a study: a pose is established broadly, while a smaller area receives more sustained description.

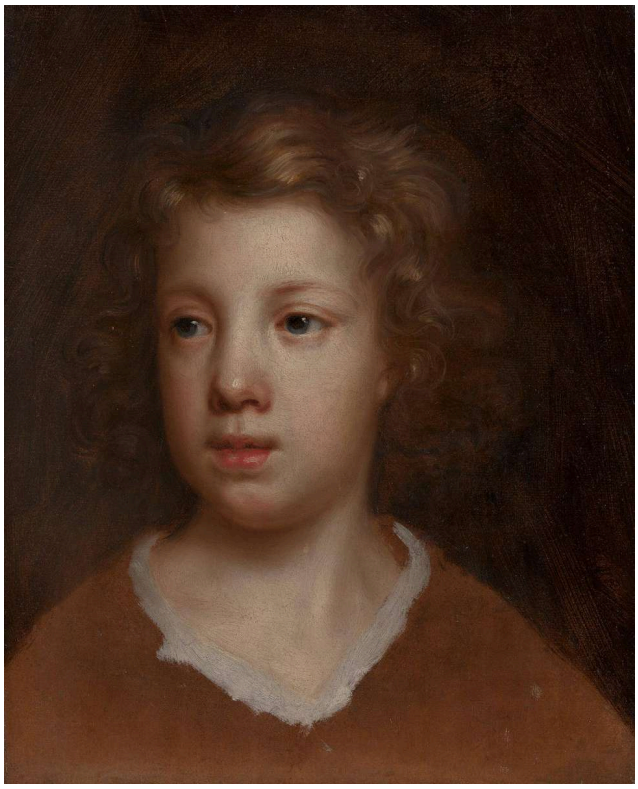
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1975.4.681

09 / 20

Bartholomew Beale

Mary Beale

1663–1664 · Yale Center for British Art



Mary Beale. Bartholomew Beale. Image credit: Mary Beale; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

Light touches one cheek more strongly than the other as the child's face turns beneath loose hair. Mary Beale uses small tonal differences to make the head substantial without loading the portrait with setting or possessions. The pale collar marks its lower boundary. That restricted field keeps the sitter's particular features in view, while the slight turn prevents the close likeness from becoming a rigid frontal diagram.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B2016.24

10 / 20

First Class: The Meeting

Abraham Solomon

1855 · Yale Center for British Art



Abraham Solomon. First Class - The Meeting. "And at first meeting loved.". Image credit: Abraham Solomon (1824 - 1862) – Artist (British) Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: QgFGq1XLeArz7Q at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Two men converse across the railway compartment while a young woman sits near the window. Bags and clothes crowd the foreground, reducing the space between the occupants. Solomon makes travel's confinement useful for a social narrative: people must share a setting even when their attention is divided. The compartment establishes the conditions for an encounter without requiring the viewer to mistake the painted scene for an unarranged report.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1987.26.3

11 / 20

Study for The Shearers

Samuel Palmer

1833–1834 · Yale Center for British Art



Samuel Palmer. Study for "The Shearers". Image credit: Samuel Palmer; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

Curved tools and a small group of objects occupy an otherwise sparse sheet. Palmer separates these details from the larger rural scene named in the title, giving their edges and overlaps room to be considered on their own. The blank surroundings are useful working space. A narrative involving people and landscape can depend on such modest pieces of equipment, studied where they do not have to compete with either.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B2014.5.74

12 / 20

Christmas

Samuel Palmer

1850 · Yale Center for British Art



Samuel Palmer. Christmas. Image credit: Samuel Palmer; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

A cloaked figure passes near a cottage among bare trees and dark foliage. Dense lines bring building and vegetation into the same winter darkness, while a small light area helps distinguish the cottage. Palmer gives the figure a route through this worked surface without explaining a complete story. The scene depends on how little light is available, and on what that little allows us to separate from its surroundings.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1977.14.10907

13 / 20

Interior of the New Bedford

Spencer Gore

1908–1909 · Yale Center for British Art



Spencer Gore. Interior of the New Bedford. Image credit: Spencer Gore; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

Tall arches and decorative divisions rise above a small crowd. Gore's darker passages clarify the interior's structure, while quicker marks keep its occupants present below. The contrast of scales is essential: the audience makes the architecture's height measurable, and the architecture gathers otherwise scattered people into one public place. The drawing's shared network of lines holds both without giving every person or ornament equal definition.

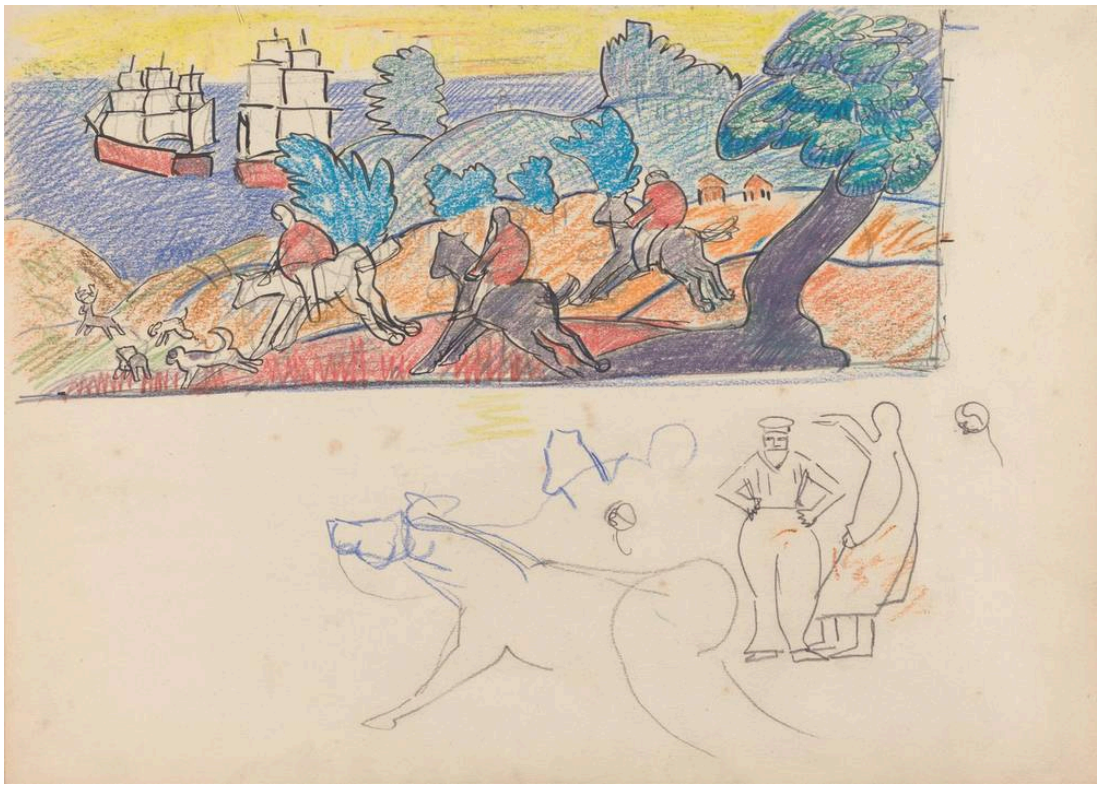
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1980.15

14 / 20

Study for a Deer-Hunting Mural

Spencer Gore

1912 · Yale Center for British Art



Spencer Gore. Cave of the Golden Calf: Study for Deer Hunting Mural. Image credit: Spencer Gore; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

A coloured scene of figures and animals sits above more spare sketches on the same sheet. Gore lets a developed arrangement coexist with parts still being tested. Trees, water and ground become broad areas that would need to read as a decorative whole, while smaller studies isolate particular decisions. The page preserves the difference between solving one pose and fitting many poses into a continuous design.

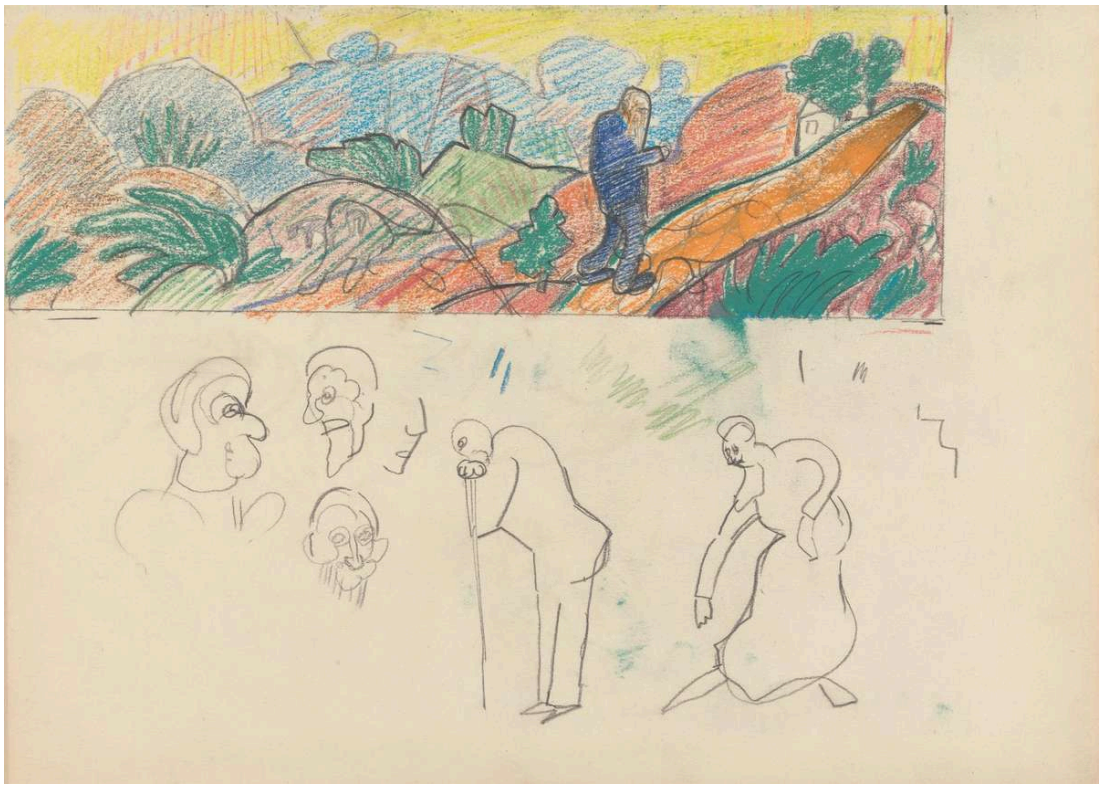
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1985.25.2

15 / 20

Study for a Mural: Old Man in a Landscape

Spencer Gore

1912 · Yale Center for British Art



Spencer Gore. Cave of the Golden Calf: Study for a Mural Decoration, Old Man in Landscape. Image credit: Spencer Gore; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

The standing figure occupies a narrow, brightly divided landscape, with smaller outline studies below. Gore is working at more than one scale of attention: the upper design tests the figure's place in a whole, while the lower sketches leave room for alternatives. Unused paper keeps these tasks separate. What might become a continuous wall decoration is still visible here as a set of decisions made alongside one another.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1985.25.1

16 / 20

The Entrance Front of Hayley's House at Eartham

William Blake

1801 · Yale Center for British Art



William Blake. The Entrance Front of Hayley's House at Eartham. Image credit: William Blake; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

The house is lightly outlined among trees, with small touches of colour and broad areas left nearly bare. Blake's selective description makes a particular building recognisable without filling every part of the sheet. More clearly stated trees help place the faint architecture. The view demonstrates how few boundaries may be needed to record a place, provided their relationships are sufficiently precise.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1981.25.2396

17 / 20

The Exeter College Eight on the Isis

William Turner of Oxford

1824 · Yale Center for British Art



William Turner. The Exeter College Eight on the Isis, Oxford. Image credit: William Turner; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

The long rowing boat repeats the horizontal direction of the banks and calm water. Trees and low buildings extend beyond it, with reflections occupying much of the foreground. William Turner of Oxford keeps the sporting subject within a larger riverside view rather than isolating the crew for close inspection. Their movement belongs to the landscape's structure, a narrow active element among longer stretches of relative stillness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B2001.2.1293

18 / 20

Bridge at Corpo di Cava

Hannah Emma Palmer

1838 · Yale Center for British Art



Hannah Emma Palmer. Bridge at Corpo di Cava. Image credit: Hannah Emma Palmer; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

The small stone bridge crosses a rough cleft surrounded by thin branches, rock and subdued washes of colour. Hannah Emma Palmer keeps its built shape clear without detaching it from the terrain. The crossing makes sense because the ground is uneven: its function and its form are read together. Layered vegetation complicates the view, but does not obscure the connection the bridge establishes between the slopes.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1982.20

19 / 20

Tysoe Windmill and Church, Warwickshire

William Turner of Oxford

1849 · Yale Center for British Art



William Turner. Tysoe Windmill and Church, Warwickshire. Image credit: William Turner; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

A windmill rises above a low horizon, surrounded by lightly marked ground and details that remain faint. William Turner of Oxford allows open paper to make the upright structure conspicuous. Adding more incident would change that relationship: the mill's proportions are easier to register because so little competes with them. The sheet records a place while leaving much of its surface available as light and distance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1975.3.994

20 / 20

Scene near Shipton on Cherwell

William Turner of Oxford

1835 · Yale Center for British Art



William Turner. Scene near Shipton on Cherwell, Oxfordshire. Image credit: William Turner; Source credit: Yale Center for British Art. Wikimedia Commons. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/deed.en). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · CC0

Water lilies spread across the near river, while the banks draw together towards an opening farther away. Their leaves work at two scales: individual shapes close to us, then a pattern belonging to a continuous stretch of water. William Turner of Oxford uses that shift to connect surface detail with distance. The river can be inspected in small pieces without losing its direction through the landscape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: B1981.24

Leave room for the studies

The comet and eruption are conspicuous subjects, but the spare tools on Palmer's sheet or Gore's alternative poses deserve another pace of looking. Compare worked and unworked areas before deciding that a drawing is merely incomplete. This selection includes paintings, prints and drawings; collection membership does not guarantee display. Check the museum's current records and access arrangements for particular works, especially works on paper.

Further reading

The Elements of Drawing

John Ruskin · Read free · English

Ruskin’s drawing exercises ask the reader to look carefully at leaves, buildings, light and edges. They offer practical comparisons for the landscape drawings here, though his judgments should be read as those of a particular nineteenth-century writer.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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